

UNIT 4 : CONSUMERISM

<https://www.wordreference.com/fren/consommation>

Concept about the individual behaviours in the society. Suggests that the individual act behaves rationally and we act because we are self interested. Try to maximise what he does to his self-being.

Decision maker.

Consumerism = broad concept, an ideology.

Acquisition and use of goods and service

⇒ aspect of homo oeconomicus : research of well-being and organisation of consummation.

Buy : useful ?

Debate over the moral ethic of consumerism :

- materialist ? morally good ?
- marketing and advertising : make profit by people buying more and more goods.
Beginning of the 19th century (invention of the press) → pamphlets, books...
Particular lifestyle.
Started in Manhattan.
Flourished in the mid 20th c (50'-60') → cigarettes (wealth, dandy)
- Credit & debt : some got indebted to buy products
1920' : beginning of the credit cards

2 periods :

- Post WWI = the Roaring Twenties → short-lived period.
- Post WWII= booming period, the Glorious Thirty.
- Global = a world affair but lots of people living in extreme poverty
Began with a local consuming and became global.
Nowadays : green consumerism.

Uk & US : both highly influential

First the UK : empire & IR = forerunners / pioneers of mechanisation

→ More US : mass production : Ford's assembly lines

→ Influence :

- Cultural : media, entertainment, lifestyle model
- Financial : gold, currency (\$)...

HISTORY

Colonial Period

16th c : stayed inside their own countries. Habit = having what you need.

→ Key words : frugality & scarcity.

→ ⇒ ⇒ Consumer revolution

Journey between Africa and America = middle passage

Transatlantic slave trade / triangular trade

Europe = manufactured goods → Africa = slaves → America = raw materials

Exchanges with India (UK) : dyes, indigo, tea, spices.

New markets. New products = symbol of wealth so aristocracy.

Upper classes in colonies = colonial gentry → consuming behaviours.

First market place = 1607 : London, "the New Exchange" by Robert Cecil in the Strand.

Some people imitated furniture, porcelain... with cheaper raw materials and a design more western → Middle classes could afford it = semi

Counterfeit culture.

The IR

UK = 1760-1840

US = 1870-WWI

Manufacturing developed.

Exodus (agricultural countryside to the cities) = flood. New city social class = worker class.

Consumption went beyond necessity. Buying without needing it (pleasure, wealth).

Department stores : Macy's (NYC), Harrods (London), Debenhams (Oxford).

Steam engines → transportation.

1890' (US) : transcontinental railway (East-West) so mail-order shopping.

Consumer society took time before it flourished because the 1st generation of workers were very poor and could not afford more than bread and potatoes.

1834 : Social Reform (UK).

The Post-War Periods

- 1920'

US : prohibition (alcohol), speakeasies.

→ The Great Gatsby, Fitzgerald

Automobiles, telephones, films, radio

Workers were considered as true consumers so, they started to be the target for the products, the companies realised that if they wanted to sell more, they needed their workers to have more money and more free time → new work ethic.

Department stores continued to dvp :

- US : turned into entertainment places = permanent fairs

Some figures (US) :

- Electricity : number of households with it x2 (1921-1929) from 35% to 68%. Radio = good medium to advertise, refrigerators = buy more products.
- Motorcars : registers = 8M to 28M.
- Time payment arrangements

- GLORIOUS THIRTY

Raising standards of living.

Mass consumer society.

TV → advertising rocketed.

Media are / a medium is

1960' : starting of the plan obsolescence.

- **Vance Packard, The Waste Makers** 1960 : two forms of obsolescence :
 - Functional
 - Psychological : ***"obsolete in the mind of the consumer, even sooner than the components used to make them will fail."***

Movements (Civil Rights) → particular society because they claimed smtg, wanted to pass on a message. The economists say it was the decade of the selling of opinions. The manner of consuming means smtg.

The Digital Revolution & Green Revolution

Idea of voluntary simplicity, motivated by environmental concerns and economic hardships, changed the consumer habits.

Religious reasons : Quakers. Environmental and health : Hippies.

GREEN CONSUMERISM = a form of consumption that safeguards the environment for the present and future generations (biodegradable, recycled, low-energy used products)

DIGITAL ERA : 21st century = can shop anywhere at any time, delivered.

E-commerce : UK = over 70% of people shop online.

Individuals have power. Shift for media and advertising companies and the consumers themselves (can compare, check the opinions...)

REFERENCES

- **John Kenneth Galbraith, "How Much Should a Country Consume?"**

Notion of consumption and its implications for society.

In affluent societies, the focus on ever-increasing consumption has reached excessive levels, leading to social and environmental consequences.

Societies should reevaluate their priorities, shifting away from a relentless pursuit of material goods and towards a more balanced approach that prioritizes social well-being and sustainability.

Importance of addressing inequality and ensuring that basic needs are met for all citizens before pursuing further consumption.

Sustainability.

America's unprecedented consumption levels since World War I and its implications for resource management. It criticizes the focus on economic growth without addressing excessive consumption. It highlights the reluctance to question consumption standards due to beliefs about individual freedom, tradition, and economic reliance on production. **The author suggests shifting consumption patterns towards less material-intensive goods and services to address resource challenges**

- Bernard MANDEVILL's influential work, The Fable of the Bees (1714)
A country's prosperity ultimately lies in the self-interest of the consumer.

- Edward BERNAYS, Propaganda 1928
*"Today supply (...) cannot afford to wait until the public asks for its products; it must maintain constant touch, through advertising and propaganda, to **assure itself the continuous demand** which alone will make its costly plant profitable."*

- JJ Rousseau, "Discourse on the Origin and Basis of Inequality Among Men »

« Brillo box » Warhol

- Adam Smith, The Wealth of nation